defend Taiwan militarily nor significantly increase aid to Jiang's regime. In a speech on Asia, the secretary of state also laid out a "defensive perimeter" that omitted Taiwan and Korea.

That speech also contained themes about the problems and solutions in Asia that Indian officials would have found familiar. It identified "revulsion" against poverty and foreign domination as the primary factors driving Asians. Furthermore, Acheson emphasized vulnerability to communist subversion as a key threat and the need to look beyond military means as a solution.[112]

In testimony on Capitol Hill, Acheson also stressed that there was "no easy or early solution" to the China situation—and definitely not a military one. The "real center" of American interest in Asia, he emphasized, must lie in the "crescent of countries" around China, with Japan and India at its crucial ends. He acknowledged, however, that these two "major anchors" were facing significant problems at that stage.[113]

Both within and outside Congress, there was criticism that the administration did not then seem to have a plan to strengthen countries like India. The administration had not outlined how it was going to contain communism in Asia—nothing "bold," like a "Marshall Plan for Asia," was on the table. Senator Styles Bridges (R-NH) said the situation begged the question of whether Americans were "men in Europe and mice in Asia."[114]

There was also criticism of India. Nehru had conveyed the hope via K. P. S. Menon that the US "would not take amiss" India's early recognition.[115] But this was wishful thinking. Recognition reinforced the growing sense in Washington that India might not be the hoped-for solution to the China conundrum. Before Indian recognition, a map of Asia in the *New York Times* outlining the spread and threat of communism had highlighted India as a "non-communist strong point," with a label that read "West counts on Nehru for support in long run."[116] A month later, postrecognition, in a similar map that statement had become a question: "Will India supply effective anti-communist leadership?"[117] Commentators lamented that India "h[eld] the key" to any defense of Asia and yet its attitude was "dangerous."[118]

Other episodes in early 1950 only exacerbated the negative feelings toward India in the US. Nehru publicly criticized the American attitude toward China as unnecessarily confrontational.[119] At the UN Security